
PSC 7000: Research Methods and Approaches in Political Science

Villanova University

Graduate Seminar, Fall 2025

Tuesdays 5:20-7:20PM

Instructor: Prof. Ryan Weldzius

Class Location: [Zoom](#)

Office hours: Tuesdays 2:30-4:30pm ([sign-up here](#))

Office hours: [Zoom](#)

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COURSE DESCRIPTION:

This course introduces graduate students to the fundamentals of political science research, including the development of research questions, argument construction, case selection, and the use of both qualitative and quantitative methods. The course aims to help students read and critique academic literature, design a research proposal, and conduct basic data analysis in R. It is split into two parts: the first half emphasizes qualitative research design and theory-building, and the second focuses on quantitative methods and operationalization.

COURSE OBJECTIVES:

- Critically analyze political science literature
 - Formulate testable research questions and hypotheses
 - Design qualitative and quantitative research strategies
 - Gain proficiency in R for data management and analysis
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LEARNING METHODOLOGY:

This course is structured as an applied, discussion-based graduate seminar, with a balance of conceptual learning and hands-on practice. Class time will combine short lectures to introduce core methodological concepts with interactive exercises that allow you to immediately apply those concepts to real-world research problems.

The first half of the course focuses on qualitative research design and theory development. You will work through case selection strategies, process tracing, and comparative analysis, often critically engaging with published political science studies. The second half turns to quantitative methods, introducing you to data operationalization, measurement, and analysis

in R. We will work with actual datasets to reinforce skills in data wrangling, visualization, and statistical inference.

The first half of the course will be highly discussion-based. Students are expected to participate in all classes. In-class discussions will focus on critically engaging with assigned readings, debating methodological choices, and collaboratively working through research design challenges. On days when assignments are due, students will be selected at random to briefly present on their research project.

The second half of the course will blend asynchronous and in-person learning. Video lectures will be posted before class so that students can review core concepts and methods at their own pace. This will free up in-class time for shorter, more focused tutorials and discussions that apply the lecture material to real research problems. Tutorials will include coding exercises in R, hands-on data analysis, and peer review of research proposals. On days when assignments are due, students will again be selected at random to briefly present on their research project.

The course will culminate with an original research project. Students will work on this project throughout the semester, with small goals every couple of weeks. In the final week of classes, students will present a draft of their final project to the class and receive feedback on their progress. The final paper will be due on the date of the final exam.

ASSIGNMENTS AND GRADING:

Attendance and participation (15%)

Active participation is essential for the success in this course. The seminar format in the first half of the semester relies on everyone completing the required readings and fully participating in the discussions. In the second half, in-class tutorials and activities build directly on the assigned video lectures, so thorough preparation before class is expected. Students should attend all sessions, actively contribute to discussions and group work, and be ready to present or respond to questions when called upon. Each student will give 1–2 short presentations in each half of the semester. If you need to miss a class, please inform me in advance and arrange to catch up on the material and assignments.

Weekly discussion questions (15%)

The discussion questions for each week are listed on this syllabus (see Schedule below). Students must answer these questions each week and submit a brief written response (approximately 400–500 words) to Blackboard. Responses are due before each class, on **Mondays by 11:59 pm ET**. No late posts will be accepted, so please plan accordingly.

Your posts should be thoughtful, draw on the assigned readings, and, when appropriate, connect to broader debates in political science research. I will review the posts before class and may highlight selected responses to guide our discussions.

Research assignments (25%)

Research assignments are listed below on specific weeks. These assignments are designed to scaffold your larger research project by breaking it into smaller, low-stakes tasks. **Each assignment is due by 11:59 pm ET on Monday** of the week indicated.

These assignments are directly related to your research project and are intended to help you practice critical skills such as formulating research questions, designing a research strategy, selecting cases, and preparing data for analysis. Completing these assignments on time will ensure that you stay on track for the larger project and receive timely feedback.

In the second half of the class, these research assignments can be found in your weekly homework assignments, which contain applied statistical readings and toy examples for you to work through. These toy examples will also ask you to use your own data to complete a particular task (e.g., create a scatter plot of your key variables).

Midterm literature review (15%)

Students will submit an 8–10 page, double-spaced literature review with in-text citations and a full bibliography. You may use any citation style (e.g., MLA, APA, Chicago) as long as it is applied consistently. Begin with a paragraph outlining your research question and argument, then provide a narrative literature review that situates your question within the broader academic literature. The review should go beyond summarizing readings, demonstrating engagement with research methods concepts, and constructing a coherent argument about your topic. **Due on Friday, October 10th by 5pm ET.**

Problem sets in R (10%)

Students will complete two problem sets in R. The first problem set will be graded for completion and is designed to prepare you for the second. The second problem set will be graded for correctness, assessing your ability to apply data management and analysis skills in R. Both problem sets scaffold your learning and help build proficiency for your research projects.

Final paper and presentation (20%)

The final paper replaces the traditional final exam and requires students to integrate all elements of the course. During the first half of the semester, you will have developed your research question, argument, testable hypotheses, and literature review. In the second half, you will work on cleaning a dataset, creating useful visualizations of your data, and testing your hypotheses using a simple statistical analysis. The final submission focuses on updating each of the aforementioned elements based on feedback from your classmates and the instructor. Your paper must include at least one qualitative component (e.g., a case study) and one quantitative component (e.g., linear regression), although you are welcome to incorporate additional methods as appropriate. **Due Tuesday, December 16 by 5:00pm ET.**

Late submissions

Late submissions will be lowered by one letter grade for each day late; after the third day

(36 hours after the due date) the assignment will receive a zero. This does not include the discussion questions, which will receive a zero if submitted late.

GRADE DISTRIBUTION:

Grade Scale: There are a total of 100 points to earn in the course, thus each point is worth 1% of your final grade. NB: I will not round up grades; if you receive 89.9 points, your final grade will be a B+. Here is the grade scale: 94-100, A; 90-93, A-; 88-89, B+; 84-87, B; 80-83, B-; . . . 0-60, F.

Grade Appeals. If you believe you received an incorrect grade on an assignment, you can formally appeal it to me. The appeal will consist of a one-page typed explanation that identifies the problem and presents a reasoned argument for the proposed change.

READINGS:

The course readings will be drawn from one textbook on research methods (available for purchase in the bookstore), several scholarly research articles, and an online quantitative methods textbook (free). All readings (not from the assigned book) will be made available on Blackboard or links will be available on the syllabus.

Howard, Christopher. *Thinking Like a Political Scientist: A Practical Guide to Research Methods*. University of Chicago Press, 2017.

COMPUTER REQUIREMENTS:

This course requires a personal computer (laptop or desktop) capable of running the necessary software. Notebooks, Chromebooks, and most tablets will not suffice. In the second half of the course, students will need to install and use the open-source statistical software R for data analysis and problem sets. Falvey Library has computers on loan if needed.

OFFICE HOURS:

I am available for virtual office hours on Tuesdays 2:30-4:30pm. Please sign-up for a 15-minute time slot via [Calendly](#). If you cannot make these times, please write to me in advance and we will find a time that is suitable for us both.

LEARNING SUPPORT, ACADEMIC INTEGRITY, AND ABSENCES:

Office for Access & Disability Services (ADS) and Learning Support Services (LSS) It is the policy of Villanova to make reasonable academic accommodations for qualified

individuals with disabilities. All students who need accommodations should go to [Clockwork for Students](#) via myNOVA to complete the Online Intake or to send accommodation letters to professors. Go to the LSS website <http://learningsupportservices.villanova.edu> or the ADS website <https://www1.villanova.edu/university/student-life/ads.html> for registration guidelines and instructions. If you have any questions please contact LSS at 610- 519-5176 or learning.support.services@villanova.edu, or ADS at 610-519-3209 or ods@villanova.edu.

Academic Integrity: All students are expected to uphold Villanova's Academic Integrity Policy and Code. Any incident of academic dishonesty will be reported to the Graduate Studies Dean of the College of Liberal Arts and Sciences for [disciplinary action](#). You may view the [University's Academic Integrity Policy and Code](#) for a detailed description. If a student is found responsible for an academic integrity violation, which results in a grade penalty, they may not WX the course unless they are approved to WX for significant medical reasons. Students applying for a WX based on significant medical reasons, must submit documentation and their request for an exception will be considered.

Use of Artificial Intelligence: Students are permitted to use AI tools (e.g., Copilot, ChatGPT, and other generative AI) only as a supplement to assist in understanding, troubleshooting, or improving their own work. In the second half of the course, AI may be used to help identify errors on homework and problem sets, but it must not be used to generate complete solutions. **Any use of AI must be explicitly cited and a complete printout of the conversation submitted.** Failure to cite AI use will result in an automatic zero on the assignment. The second infraction will result in a failure of the course, but can also lead to removal from the program. Students are responsible for understanding and following these rules for all assignments.

Absences for Religious Holidays: Villanova University makes every reasonable effort to allow members of the community to observe their religious holidays, consistent with the University's obligations, responsibilities, and policies. Students who expect to miss a class or assignment due to the observance of a religious holiday should discuss the matter with their professors as soon as possible, normally at least two weeks in advance. Absence from classes or examinations for religious reasons does not relieve students from responsibility for any part of the course work required during the absence. <https://www1.villanova.edu/villanova/provost/resources/student/policies/religiousholidays.html>

COURSE SCHEDULE:

Week 1: Asking good questions and making inferences

- **Date:** August 26
- **Core themes:** What makes a research question interesting and important? What counts as an inference in political science?
- **Reading:**

- Howard, Preface & Introduction.
 - **Discussion questions (in-class):** What are some research questions that you have? Did you write original research papers in your undergraduate studies? If so, what were some of the topics?
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Week 2: Finding good sources and writing a literature review

- **Date:** September 2
- **Core themes:** This week focuses on how to locate and evaluate high-quality scholarly sources in political science and how to synthesize them into a coherent review of the literature. We will examine strategies for searching political science databases, identifying peer-reviewed work, and distinguishing between theoretical, methodological, and empirical contributions. Students will learn to assess the credibility and relevance of sources, organize them thematically, and position their own research questions within an existing scholarly conversation.
- **Guest speaker:** Sara Marx, Social Science Librarian
- **Readings:**
 - Howard, Chapter 1.
 - Knopf, Jeffrey W. “Doing a literature review.” *PS: Political Science & Politics* 39, no. 1 (2006): 127-132.
 - Hessami, Zohal, and Mariana Lopes da Fonseca. “Female political representation and substantive effects on policies: A literature review.” *European Journal of Political Economy* 63 (2020).
 - Helpful Guide: [University of Toronto Tip-Sheet](#). (Not required reading for class; save for later)

** Discussion questions (due Monday, September 1, by 11:59pm):

- How have you looked for scholarly sources in the past?
 - In Hessami and Lopes da Fonseca’s article, what mechanisms does the literature propose to explain how female political representation produces policy changes? How might these mechanisms differ across policy domains such as health, education, or economics?
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Week 3: Description versus explanation

- **Date:** September 9
- **Core themes:** This week explores the distinction between describing political phenomena and explaining them. We will discuss the value and limits of descriptive research, how it can stand alone as a contribution or serve as a foundation for causal inference, and the challenges of moving from observation to explanation. Students will

learn to identify the type of inference being made in a piece of research, evaluate how the authors balance descriptive detail with analytical argument, and evaluate the kinds of evidence used to support each approach.

- **Reading:**

- Howard, Chapters 2 and 6.
- Gerring, John. “Mere description.” *British Journal of Political Science* 42, no. 4 (2012): 721-746.
- Mutz, Diana C., and Amber Hye-Yon Lee. “How much is one American worth? How competition affects trade preferences.” *American Political Science Review* 114, no. 4 (2020): 1179-1194.

- ** **Discussion questions:**

- Is “mere description” enough to count as valuable political science research? Why or why not?
- How do Mutz and Lee describe the public’s trade preferences? What patterns emerge before the theory enters the picture?

- ** **Research Assignment:** [1pt]

- Draft two research questions. Write a short paragraph (for each question) about why it matters and what you think you might infer. Name the document Last-Name_PSC7000_ResearchProject_v1.pdf. Also, write your research questions on a PowerPoint slide (or other presentation software) in preparation for the class.

Week 4: Theory building and hypothesis testing

- **Date:** September 16

- **Core themes:** This week examines how political scientists develop theories, derive hypotheses, and design strategies to test them. We will explore the role of theory in framing research questions, the importance of linking hypotheses directly to theoretical claims, and the use of counterfactual reasoning to strengthen causal arguments. Special attention will be given to process tracing as a method for identifying and evaluating causal mechanisms within case studies. Students will learn how to move from abstract theoretical concepts to concrete, testable propositions and how to assess whether evidence convincingly supports or challenges a given hypothesis.

- **Reading:**

- Howard, Chapter 3.
- Fearon, James D. “Counterfactuals and hypothesis testing in political science.” *World politics* 43, no. 2 (1991): 169-195.
- Collier, David. “Understanding process tracing.” *PS: Political Science & Politics* 44, no. 4 (2011): 823-830.

**** Discussion questions:**

- How do Collier’s arguments about process tracing complement or challenge Fearon’s emphasis on counterfactual reasoning for causal inference? In what types of political science research might one method be preferable over the other?
- Fearon emphasizes formal hypothesis testing and counterfactual logic, while Collier focuses on detailed case-level evidence. How could a researcher studying a political crisis or policy decision design a study that effectively integrates insights from both approaches? How could *you* integrate this into your own research project?

**** Research Assignment:** [2pts]

- Stemming from your approved research question, draft your argument and at least two testable hypotheses. Add this to your “ResearchProject” document and submit as a new PDF on Blackboard (LastName_PSC7000_ResearchProject_v2.pdf). Add these to your PowerPoint presentation.

Week 5: Choosing a research design

- **Date:** September 23
- **Core themes:** This week focuses on how to select a research design that best aligns with your research question and theoretical framework. We will compare different approaches to causal inference, including within-case and cross-case analysis, and discuss the trade-offs between depth and breadth, and control and generalizability. Students will consider how time, resources, and data availability influence design choices, as well as how research designs shape the strength and type of conclusions that can be drawn. The goal is to develop the ability to clearly justify design choices and anticipate potential limitations before conducting the study.
- **Reading:**
 - Howard, Chapter 4.
 - Goertz, Gary, and James Mahoney. “Within-case versus cross-case causal analysis.” In *A Tale of Two Cultures*. Princeton University Press, 2012: 87-99.
 - Kono, Daniel Y. “Optimal Obfuscation: Democracy and Trade Policy Transparency.” *American Political Science Review* 101, no. 3 (2007): 425–443.

**** Discussion questions:**

- Goertz and Mahoney discuss the different goals and strengths of within-case versus cross-case causal analysis. How does Kono’s study illustrate these trade-offs in practice? Could his findings have been strengthened or weakened by using the alternative approach?

- In what ways does Kono’s use of case-level evidence and variation in transparency rules exemplify within-case causal logic? How might a cross-case design have changed the way causal claims are drawn in his study?

**** Research Assignment:** [3pts]

- Identify 15 peer-reviewed sources related to your research question. Group them into two categories: (1) directly addresses your research question and/or (2) contributes relevant theory or methods. Ensure that the citations are correct. Name the file LastName_Bibliography_v1.pdf and submit on Blackboard by Monday by 11:59pm.

Week 6: Case selection and comparative analysis

- **Date:** September 30
- **Core themes:** This week focuses on the critical role of case selection in comparative research. We explore various strategies—such as choosing representative, deviant, most likely, or least likely cases—and how these choices impact the validity and generalizability of findings. The readings highlight systematic approaches to justify case selection, linking it closely to research questions and theoretical goals. Understanding these methods helps strengthen comparative analysis and ensures that cases are chosen thoughtfully to support robust conclusions.
- **Reading:**
 - Howard, Chapter 5.
 - Seawright, Jason, and John Gerring. “Case selection techniques in case study research: A menu of qualitative and quantitative options.” *Political Research Quarterly* 61, no. 2 (2008): 294-308.
 - Haggard, Stephan, and Sylvia Maxfield. “The political economy of financial internationalization in the developing world.” *International Organization* 50, no. 1 (1996): 35-68.

**** Discussion questions:**

- How do Haggard and Maxfield justify their selection of Chile, Indonesia, Mexico, and South Korea for analyzing financial internationalization? In what ways does their approach reflect or diverge from Seawright and Gerring’s typology of case selection strategies, such as most-likely, least-likely, or deviant cases?
- Considering Seawright and Gerring’s discussion of trade-offs between analytical rigor and generalizability, to what extent can the findings from these four case studies be generalized to other developing countries? How do the authors balance the depth of within-case analysis with the broader applicability of their results?

Week 7: Biases and pitfalls in research

- **Date:** October 7
- **Core themes:** This week examines common sources of bias and error in political science research, with a focus on how these problems can distort findings and weaken causal claims. We will explore issues such as selection bias, omitted variable bias, measurement error, and confirmation bias, considering how they arise in both qualitative and quantitative designs. An emphasis will be placed on identifying potential pitfalls early in the research process and developing strategies to mitigate them. Students will practice diagnosing bias in published work and in their own projects, sharpening their ability to critically evaluate research quality.
- **Reading:**
 - Howard, Chapter 5.
 - Geddes, Barbara. “How the cases you choose affect the answers you get: Selection bias and related issues.” In *Paradigms and sand castles: Theory building and research design in comparative politics*. University of Michigan Press, 2003. [[Online access to book here; requires Villanova login.](#)]
 - Cassan, Guilhem, and Milan Van Steenvoort. “Political regime and COVID 19 death rate: Efficient, biasing or simply different autocracies? An econometric analysis.” *SSM-Population Health* 16 (2021): 100912. (focus on the biases; don’t get stuck on the empirical analysis)

**** Discussion questions:**

- How does selection bias influence the validity of comparative research findings, and in what ways does Cassan and Van Steenvoort’s study illustrate these concerns when comparing autocracies and democracies in COVID-19 outcomes?
- What strategies can researchers use to detect or mitigate bias, such as omitted variable bias or confounding, in cross-national analyses like the one conducted by Cassan and Van Steenvoort?

**** Midterm literature review due by Friday, October 10th at 5pm ET: [20pts]**

- 8–10 pages long, double-spaced, 12 point font. Use in-text citations and include a full bibliography/references at the end. Choose the citation style with which you are most comfortable (e.g., MLA, APA, Chicago) and use consistently/correctly throughout your literature review.
- Start the literature review with a paragraph that describes your research question and argument. Then go straight into the literature review. Remember, you are not just summarizing the readings; you are providing a narrative that situates your research question in a broader literature. You should also utilize the language of research methods that you have learned so far.

Week 8: Fall Break

- **Date:** October 14

- **Assignment:** relax.
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Week 9: Operationalization and R Basics

- **Date:** October 21
 - **Core themes:** This week centers on the operationalization of complex concepts and an introduction to basic data analysis using R. We examine how multifaceted ideas like governance are measured through composite indicators, addressing challenges such as integrating diverse perception data and interpreting margins of error. The readings provide insight into the methodological transparency and rigor in indicator construction. Students will apply these principles to their own projects by defining a concept, identifying data sources, and outlining a strategy for creating a reliable and valid index or scale.
 - **Reading:**
 - *Review:* Howard, Chapter 2, pp. 49–60.
 - Kaufmann, Daniel and Aart C. Kraay. “The Worldwide Governance Indicators : Methodology and 2024 Update (English).” Policy Research working paper: *World Bank Group*. <http://documents.worldbank.org/curated/en/099005210162424110>.
 - Wickham, Hadley and Garrett Grolmund, “R for Data Science.” Chapter 1. [Skip 1.3, 1.7, and 1.8.]
 - **Online lecture:** watch lecture(s) for Week 9.
- ** Discussion questions:**
- Focusing on the sections on indicator definition, data sources, and aggregation methodology: How is the concept of governance operationalized across multiple indicators? What challenges arise in combining perceptions data from diverse sources? How do margins of error help interpret the measurement?
- ** Assignment:** [2pts]
- Complete Homework 1.
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Week 10: Data Wrangling and Sources

- **Date:** October 28
- **Core themes:** This week focuses on the practical skills needed to locate, evaluate, and prepare data for political science research. We will discuss how to assess data quality, coverage, and relevance, as well as the trade-offs between different sources such as surveys, administrative records, and archival datasets. Students will gain hands-on experience with ICPSR and other repositories to identify datasets that fit their research questions. We will also introduce the basics of data wrangling in R, including importing, inspecting, and cleaning datasets, with attention to common challenges like

missing values, inconsistent formats, and variable coding. The aim is to develop both the critical eye to choose strong data sources and the technical skills to get them ready for analysis.

- **Reading:**

- Howard, Chapter 7.
- Visit the ICPSR webpage and familiarize yourself with the available data sources: <https://www.icpsr.umich.edu/web/pages/ICPSR/index.html>.
- Wickham, Hadley and Garrett Grolemund, “R for Data Science:” Chapters 4, 5, and 11.1–11.2.

- **Online lecture:** watch lecture(s) for Week 10.

**** Discussion questions:**

- What criteria should researchers prioritize when assessing the quality, coverage, and relevance of a dataset for their specific research question? How might these priorities differ depending on whether the research is qualitative, quantitative, or mixed-methods?
- Find two datasets that could be helpful for your project and be prepared to explain what is in the dataset, such as what is the unit of analysis, what variables are included, what is the scope of the data (e.g., num. of countries/states/people, year range, etc.)?

**** Assignment:**

- Complete Homework 2. [3pts]

Week 11: Data Visualization

- **Date:** November 4

- **Core themes:**

- **Reading:**

- Kieran Healy, “Data Visualization: A Practical Introduction,” Chapter 1 – The Basics. (This may very well help you get a job one day; read carefully and save to review later.)
- Wickham, Hadley and Garrett Grolemund, “R for Data Science:” Chapter 2.
- Briefly look through the webpage “from Data to Viz.”

- **Online lecture:** watch lecture(s) for Week 11.

**** Assignment:** [3pts]

- Complete Homework 3.

**** Problem Set 1 (due Friday of Week 11 by 10 pm): [2pts]**

- Complete first problem set. This will be graded on completion but you should still take this seriously as the next problem set will be graded.

Week 12: Introduction to Regression

- **Date:** November 11
- **Core themes:** This week introduces regression analysis as a tool for understanding and quantifying relationships between variables. We will cover the structure of the simple linear regression model, how to interpret coefficients, and how to assess model fit using measures like R^2 and residual analysis.
- **Reading:**
 - Bruens, Alex. “How to Read Political Science Regression Tables.” (2023): <https://abruens.com/post/how-to-read-regression-tables/>.
 - Review Kono, Daniel Y. “Optimal Obfuscation: Democracy and Trade Policy Transparency.” *American Political Science Review* 101, no. 3 (2007): 425–443.
- **Online lecture:** watch lecture(s) for Week 12.

**** Discussion questions:**

- Looking at Kono’s regression tables, what does the coefficient on democracy indicate about its relationship with trade policy transparency? How do you interpret its magnitude and statistical significance in substantive terms?

**** Assignment: [3pts]**

- Complete Homework 4.

Week 13: Regression II

- **Date:** November 18
- **Core themes:** This week focuses on using regression for prediction and model evaluation. We apply these tools to forecast movie revenues, using log transformations, interpreting coefficients, and assessing fit with residuals and RMSE. Readings illustrate how regression informs theory in international political economy, showing how careful model design and interpretation are essential for both prediction and explanation.
- **Reading:**
 - Gowa, Joanne, and Edward D. Mansfield. “Power politics and international trade.” *American Political Science Review* 87, no. 2 (1993): 408-420.
 - Büthe, Tim, and Helen V. Milner. “The politics of foreign direct investment into developing countries: Increasing FDI through international trade agreements?” *American Journal of Political Science* 52, no. 4 (2008): 741-762.

- **Online lecture:** watch lecture(s) for Week 13.

**** Discussion questions:**

- What are the key independent and dependent variables in each study, and how are they measured?
- How do the authors use quantitative methods to test their arguments about trade and FDI?
- How do the authors deal with potential confounding factors in their regression models?

**** Assignment:** [3pts]

- Complete Homework 5.

Week 14: Regression III

- **Date:** November 25

- **Core themes:** This week focuses on binary and categorical predictors in regression, along with the basics of multiple regression. We examine how to include and interpret dummy variables, how to handle categorical variables with more than two categories, and how adding control variables in multiple regression changes the coefficient estimates. Readings reinforce these concepts by applying categorical variables to real-world political science research.

- **Reading:**

- Guisinger, Alexandra. “Determining trade policy: Do voters hold politicians accountable?” *International Organization* 63, no. 3 (2009): 533-557.
- Kleinberg, Katja B., and Benjamin O. Fordham. “Trade and foreign policy attitudes.” *Journal of Conflict Resolution* 54, no. 5 (2010): 687-714.

- **Online lecture:** watch lecture(s) for Week 14.

**** Discussion questions:**

- Both readings use categorical variables to capture different political and economic attitudes. How do they operationalize these categories, and what does this tell us about the advantages and limitations of categorical predictors in regression?
- In multiple regression, adding control variables can change the size or significance of key coefficients. In these studies, how does the inclusion of additional predictors alter the interpretation of the main independent variables?

**** Assignment:** [3pts]

- Complete Homework 6.

**** Problem Set 2:** [8pts]

- Due by Friday at 11:59pm.
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Week 15: Logistic Regression

- **Date:** December 2
- **Core themes:** This week's core themes focus on logistic regression and its use for modeling binary outcomes. Students should understand that traditional linear regression is not well-suited for binary outcomes because predicted values can fall outside the 0–1 range. Logistic regression addresses this by using a generalized linear model with a logit link function, which maps predictions onto the 0–1 probability scale. Coefficients in logistic regression reflect log odds, so interpretation focuses on the sign and statistical significance rather than a direct numeric effect. In practice, probability predictions are computed from the model for substantive interpretation.
- **Reading:**
 - Chase, Kerry A. "Economic interests and regional trading arrangements: The case of NAFTA." *International Organization* 57, no. 1 (2003): 137-174.
 - Zeng, Ka, Karen Sebold, and Yue Lu. "Global value chains and corporate lobbying for trade liberalization." *The Review of International Organizations* 15, no. 2 (2020): 409-443.

** Discussion Questions:

- How does exposure to trade influence political behavior in both readings? Are there conditions under which certain industries might support protectionism rather than liberalization?
- Find where the authors interpret their results. Write a short paragraph discussing how they are similar and how they are different.

** Assignment: [3pts]

- Complete Homework 7.
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Week 16: Presentations

- **Date:** December 9

** Assignment:

- Each student will give a 5 minute presentation of their final project followed by 5 minutes of Q&A.
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Week 17: Final Exams

- ** **Final Paper due by December 16 at 5:00pm ET.**
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